

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Recall value plays a critical part in politics, especially when the next assembly polls are just three months away. With this in mind, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi has launched a massive campaign to ensure that his face is omnipresent. He beams down from hoardings all over the state, cutting across issues. He is the saviour of the girl child, the symbol of Gujarat's agricultural revolution and also the state's new messiah. Not leaving anything to chance, divine intervention has also been sought, so you have Modi smiling down as *Sudarshandhari* Lord Krishna readying for a 'political battle'. A film is also being made on him by one of his supporters.

'Modi mania' seems to have caught on in the state. On Janamashtami, Surat came alive with boys clad in T-shirts emblazoned with Modi's face that proclaimed 'I love Gujarat' on their backs. In Porbandar, a lady doctor launched Aapda (our) Narendra Modi Ladies Fan Club with a membership of 15,000. "I was impressed with Narendrabhai when he announced that his Government would make it legal for people to carry their mothers' name as their surname if they so



PLAYING TO A FULL HOUSE

As assembly elections approach, Modi is everywhere—in films, DVDs, hoardings, T-shirts, mementos and even on the Internet

wanted," says Dr Nutan Gokani. "So I decided to launch a ladies fan club for him and soon discovered that scores of women like me see him as their brother." The frenzy has infiltrated the cyber world as well, with mails and sms highlighting Modi's efforts for the betterment of the state. For the Internet addicts, there are even pro- and anti-blogs and forums on the chief minister. But not everybody is ecstatic.

Modi's detractors within BJP perceive these exercises as a cultivated move by the chief minister and his supporters to build a cult around him at the expense of the party's ideology. But a majority of the state party cadre don't see anything wrong in Modi's grand projection of himself. Recently, the BJP top brass made it clear that the party would fight the forthcoming polls solely on the basis of Modi's image and instructed



STAR POWER: (Clockwise) The real Modi, actor Mishra as chief minister Jogi and Modi as Krishna party workers to extend all support to him during the election campaign. The announcement apparently came with the belated realisation that Gujarat polls will decide not just the fate of Modi but of BJP on the national electoral turf. Says Raju Iyer, a senior BJP worker who has worked with Modi,